

Grade 5 – World Geography and Ancient Civilizations I: Western Asia, the Middle East, North Africa, Sub-Saharan Africa

Overview

In grade 5, students will explore how people moved, traded, and interacted with others in early civilizations. They will learn how geography, power, wealth, and religion shaped the growth and culture of these societies. Students will focus on regions like Western Asia, the Middle East, North Africa, and Sub-Saharan Africa. They will also learn about important cultural contributions and lasting achievements. By studying ancient history, students will better understand the roots of the modern world.

Looking Back

In grade 4, students examined change and continuity within Vermont and United States history from pre-colonial times through the Civil War. Students learned the concept of movement and its impact on people, goods, and ideas and how natural resources have influenced economic development. Students examined the conflicts and compromises that resulted from migration and settlement to understand the tensions and factors that led to the fight for independence, the establishment of the United States, and civil unrest.

Looking Ahead

In grade 6, students will again explore the world and ancient civilizations by examining how movement and migration impacted the interactions between expanding civilizations through conquest and trade, including the physical and political geography and ancient societies of South and East Asia, Oceania, Latin America, and Europe. Students will note how geography, power, wealth, and religion influenced culture, change, and development within civilizations as they examine how the perspectives of political science, economics, geography, history, and archaeology apply to the study of regions and countries.



Inquiry

Why inquiry? Using inquiry as an instructional model for the teaching of social studies allows students to authentically ask questions, search for and analyze evidence, and provide explanations and arguments to challenges facing their world.

The inquiry instructional model is driven by authentic questions or problems that have relevance for children. Students learn content, skills, and dispositions as they seek answers to questions and as they apply their learning to take informed action. Pioneered by Dewey (1938), inquiry is an attempt to make classroom experiences feel more like the authentic, curiosity-driven experiences that motivate learning outside of school. ([Using Inquiry to Prepare Students for College, Career, and Civic Life](#), elementary edition, p. 22)

The Inquiry Arc is defined in Dimension 1 (questions), Dimension 3 (evidence), and Dimension 4 (communication) of the [College, Career, and Civic Life \(C3\) Framework for Social Studies State Standards](#). In the AOE-developed Proficiency-Based Learning Social Studies Hierarchy, Dimensions 1, 2, and 3, as well as evidence indicators found within Dimension 2 – History, have been combined into a singular Critical Proficiency – the Inquiry Process. Opportunities for showing proficiency in the Inquiry Process fall within the K-2, 3-5, 6-8 grade bands of the Priority Performance Indicators (below): Constructing Compelling and Supporting Questions, Gathering and Evaluating Sources, and Communicating and Critiquing Solutions. The Inquiry Process Critical Proficiency, as with all of the CPs, begins its focus in the elementary grades and spans through high school, preparing students to attain proficiency in social studies for college and career readiness.

The Critical Proficiency (CP) remains the same K-12 and identifies the enduring skills and knowledge that all students need to demonstrate (across contexts) to be prepared for future learning, including post-secondary career and college readiness. Priority Performance Indicators clarify what will be taught and assessed at each grade cluster.

Critical Proficiency (K-12): Students act as social scientists as they ask questions, think critically, solve problems, and share conclusions.

Priority Performance Indicators Priority Performance Indicators: (3-5)

Constructing Compelling and Supporting Questions: Explain why compelling and supporting questions are important and how associated ideas can be open to different interpretations. (D1. 1-3)

Gathering and Evaluating Sources: Compare information from different sources and use differences between fact and opinion to determine the credibility of the source. (D2. His. 10, 12; D3. 1-3)

Communicating and Critiquing Solutions: Use evidence from multiple sources to develop a claim or argument about the past. (D2. His. 16; D4. 1)

Overarching Themes:

- Emerging Governance (see History PPIs)
- Expanding Networks
- Shaping Civilizations
- Building Societies

Civics

Critical Proficiency (K-12): Students act as productive citizens by understanding the history foundations, and principles of our democracy through multiple lenses, and by acquiring the ability to become engaged in civic and democratic processes.

Theme: Evolving Power - See History PPIs

Priority Performance Indicator (PPI)	Sample PPI Connections	Sample Content Connections
Civic and Political Institutions Explain the origins, function, key provisions and structure of the U.S. and Vermont Constitution, including the roles and responsibilities of citizens, organizations, and governments within a democratic system. (D2. Civ. 1-6)	Note: Civic and Political Institutions PPIs are not in Grade 5 and will be addressed and assessed in Grades 3 and 4.	

Priority Performance Indicator (PPI)	Sample PPI Connections	Sample Content Connections
Civic Virtues and Democratic Principles Identify and apply core civic virtues and democratic principles that guide personal beliefs, as well as those of government, societies, and communities. (D2. Civ. 7, 8, 9, 10)	Note: Civic Virtues and Democratic Principles PPIs are not in Grade 5 and will be addressed and assessed in Grades 3 and 4.	
Rules, Processes, and Laws Explain how and why people address public problems and make changes to society. (D2. Civ. 11-14)	Note: Rules, Processes, and Laws PPIs are not in Grade 5 and will be addressed and assessed in Grades 3 and 4.	

Economics

Critical Proficiency (K-12): Students make sound economic decisions through understanding the interactions between humans, governments, economic systems and both the national and global marketplaces.

Theme: Expanding Networks

Priority Performance Indicator (PPI)	Sample PPI Connections	Sample Content Connections
Economic Decision Making Identify the incentives (positive/ negative) that influence economic decisions and the benefits and costs of such decisions. (D2. Econ. 1, 2)	Students will be able to explain how the division of labor and specialization occurred within early civilizations. Students will be able to explain how people in early civilizations made choices (trade-offs) when there were not enough resources (scarcity).	Broad Topics • Cultural diffusion • Trade practices/ trade hub development • Expansion • Technological exchange • Nomadic herding • Trade • Architectural specialization • Agricultural specialization • Trade specialization • Military • Governance • Craftsmanship Early Civilizations 1. Western Asia (Mesopotamia, Anatolia, Levant) • Agriculture: Fertile Crescent farming (wheat, barley, dates); irrigation along the Tigris and Euphrates. • Trade: Long-distance trade in metals (tin, copper), textiles, and luxury goods. • Economy: Palace and temple economies, taxation in grain and labor.

Priority Performance Indicator (PPI)	Sample PPI Connections	Sample Content Connections
Economic Decision Making (continued)	(continued)	2. Middle East (Overlap with Western Asia but includes Persia, Arabia) • Nomadic and settled economies: Mix of pastoralism (Bedouins) and urban centers. • Trade routes: Controlled key overland and maritime trade (Incense Route, Persian Royal Road). • Empire economics: Persian Empire used standardized coinage and administrative divisions. North Africa (Egypt, Carthage, Berber regions) • Nile agriculture: Predictable floods supported grain production and population growth. • State control: Centralized economy in Egypt with corvée labor and redistribution. • Trade and seafaring: Carthage dominated Mediterranean trade in grain, metals, and slaves. 3. Sub-Saharan Africa (Nok, Ghana, Nubia, Aksum) • Mining and metallurgy: Gold, iron, and salt were central to wealth. • Trans-Saharan trade: Camel caravans connected this region to North Africa and beyond. • Agriculture and pastoralism: Varied by region—yam, millet, sorghum, cattle.

Priority Performance Indicator (PPI)	Sample PPI Connections	Sample Content Connections
Exchange and Markets Explain the role of business in an economic system, including resources that are needed for production, the purpose of specialization, mediums of exchange, and the value of investments. (D2. Econ. 3, 4, 5, 6, 9)	Students will be able to explain means of exchange in early civilizations.	Mediums of Exchange: barter, trade, progression of currency development Resources: Caravans/camels, public works projects, trade routes. Market Civilizations • Mesopotamia – Specialization of labor; development of irrigation systems; wealth accumulation-armies, construction projects • Ancient Egypt – construction labor force; Nile River - predictable flooding and transportation; Pharaohs controlled resources • Ancient Persia – satrapies for regional governance and resource management; Achaemenids organized mineral extraction and trade; Darius the Great - standardized currency • Ancient Arabia – Nomadic tribes; camel caravans connecting distant places/cultures; trading hubs – Mecca and Medina • Kingdom of Mali – skilled artisans/traders (Niger River); gold mines; wealth allowed for city development – Timbuktu, construction of mosques, education • Kush – south of Egypt • Nubia – rich gold mines/kings

Priority Performance Indicator (PPI)	Sample PPI Connections	Sample Content Connections
The National Economy Explain the role of business in an economic system, including resources that are needed for production, the purpose of specialization, mediums of exchange, and the value of investments. (D2. Econ. 3, 4, 5, 6, 9)	Note: National Economy PPIs are not in Grade 5 and will be addressed and assessed in Grades 3 and 4.	

Priority Performance Indicator (PPI)	Sample PPI Connections	Sample Content Connections
The Global Economy Explain how trade leads to economic interdependence and how trade can affect some groups of people. (D2. Econ. 15)	Students will be able to explain barriers to trade and their impact on early civilizations. Students will be able to explain the economic impact of war and conflict on societies and civilizations. Students will explain how geography has played a large role in regard to specialization and economic production in early civilizations.	Trade Barriers • War and conflict • Lack of infrastructure • Lack of technology • Geographic limitations • Cultural and linguistic barriers • Climate and environmental factors • Resource scarcity • Political boundaries and regulations Economic Impact of Conflict The Crusades (1096–1291) • Region: Middle East (especially modern-day Israel, Syria, Palestine) • Conflict: Series of religious wars between Christians and Muslims. • Economic Impact: • Trade routes between Europe and the Middle East expanded. • Cities like Damascus and Jerusalem suffered destruction but also saw increased economic activity. • Boosted exchange of goods (spices, silk), ideas, and technologies.

Priority Performance Indicator (PPI)	Sample PPI Connections	Sample Content Connections
The Global Economy (continued)	(continued)	Mongol Invasions (1200s) • Region: Persia (modern-day Iran, Iraq) • Conflict: Mongols invaded and destroyed cities such as Baghdad. • Economic Impact: ○ Massive economic decline due to destruction of irrigation systems and trade centers. ○ Short-term loss of wealth, but long-term trade along the Silk Road was revived under Mongol rule. Arab Conquests (600s–700s CE) • Region: Egypt, Libya, Tunisia, Algeria, Morocco • Conflict: Arab Muslim armies conquered much of North Africa. • Economic Impact: • Spread of Arabic language and Islamic banking systems. • Growth of trade across the Sahara and the Mediterranean. • Cities like Cairo became important economic centers. Roman Conquest of North Africa (146 BCE onward) • Region: Carthage and surrounding areas • Conflict: Rome defeated Carthage in the Punic Wars. • Economic Impact: • Carthage's economy was destroyed. • Rome took control of trade in the western Mediterranean and expanded agriculture in the region.

Priority Performance Indicator (PPI)	Sample PPI Connections	Sample Content Connections
The Global Economy (continued)	(continued)	Invasion of the Songhai Empire (1591) • Region: West Africa (Mali, Niger) • Conflict: Moroccan army invaded and defeated the Songhai Empire. • Economic Impact: • Collapse of the trans-Saharan trade network. • Decline of key trading cities like Timbuktu and Gao. • Weakened political and economic power in the region. Bantu Migrations & Regional Conflict (c. 1000 BCE–1700 CE) • Region: Central and Southern Africa • Conflict: Migration often led to conflict with existing groups over land and resources.

Priority Performance Indicator (PPI)	Sample PPI Connections	Sample Content Connections
The Global Economy (continued)	(continued)	Bantu Migrations & Regional Conflict (c. 1000 BCE–1700 CE) (continued) • Economic Impact: • Spread of ironworking technology improved farming and tools. • New trade routes and markets were established. • Some regions faced food shortages or disruption due to clashes. Geography and Economic Specialization • Mesopotamia – Fertile land between two rivers; flat plains • Rich soil allowed for surplus farming (wheat, barley); surplus food supported job specialization (scribes, potters, metalworkers); location along trade routes encouraged trade with neighboring regions. • Phoenicia – Rocky coastline, limited farmland, access to the Mediterranean Sea. • Became expert shipbuilders, traders, and sailors; specialized in making purple dye and glass; built a strong economy based on maritime trade. • Ancient Egypt – Fertile land along the Nile, surrounded by deserts. • Nile floods provided reliable farming conditions (grain, papyrus); farmers, scribes, architects, and traders developed as specialized workers; surpluses allowed trade with Nubia and the Near East. • Kingdom of Ghana – Located between gold mines in the south and salt mines in the north. • Became a center for gold-salt trade across the Sahara; people specialized in mining, trading, blacksmithing, and governance; controlled trade routes and collected taxes, boosting wealth.

Priority Performance Indicator (PPI)	Sample PPI Connections	Sample Content Connections
The Global Economy (continued)	(continued)	• Kingdom of Axum – Near the Red Sea, mountainous, with access to trade routes. • Traded goods like ivory, gold, and spices with Arabia and India; specialized in farming (terrace farming) and long-distance trade; developed a written language and minted their own coins for commerce.

Resources

Agriculture - C3 IDM: Students will examine sources related to the development of agriculture, the emergence of ancient writing in Mesopotamia, and the rise of social inequalities as they construct an argument in response to the compelling question “Was the development of agriculture good for humans?”

Ancient Trade Networks - OER - History project: Local networks might have been the most common and important types of networks in this period, but long-distance regional trade networks also connected societies across Afro-Eurasia and the Americas. Trade along these routes was slow and dangerous, but it allowed for the exchange of people, goods, ideas, and diseases across many regions. The networks changed the communities they touched and transformed production and distribution in every region.

4. Analyze how regional networks of exchange came into existence and how they became larger and more interconnected over time.
5. Evaluate how the sharing of goods and ideas such as metals and iron-making skills transformed societies.
6. Map regional trade networks to understand how communities were interconnected through trade and exchange.

Mali Wealth - C3 IDM: This inquiry focuses on understanding how the Kingdom of Mali became a center of wealth in West Africa. The questions, tasks, and sources in this inquiry asks students to analyze a variety of primary and secondary sources to determine the most important factor for generating wealth in Mali: geography, trade, or religion.

Nomadic Life - C3 IDM: This inquiry leads students through an investigation of prehistoric nomadic life. By investigating the compelling question “How do we know the past without written evidence?” students evaluate how nomads communicated, where they lived, and how they defined their needs based on the places they lived. The formative

performance tasks build on knowledge and skills through the course of the inquiry and help students develop understanding of nomadic life to compare with agrarian life. Students create an evidence-based argument about how non-written artifacts support understanding of nomadic life during prehistoric times.

Geography

Critical Proficiency (K-12): Students use geographic inquiry and reasoning to propose solutions to local, national, and global issues.

Theme: Shaping Civilizations

Priority Performance Indicator (PPI)	Sample PPI Connections	Sample Content Connections
Geographic Representations: Spatial Views of the World Create and/or use maps with different scales of familiar and unfamiliar places, to explain relationships of places to their environment including cultural and environmental characteristics. (D2. Geo. 1, 2, 3)	Students will be able to create and/or use maps to explain significant patterns of settlement and movement in early civilizations.	Geography of Western Asia, the Middle East, North Africa, and Sub-Saharan Africa • Landforms • Climate • Natural resources • Fertile Crescent • Deserts • Rivers – Nile, Tigris, Euphrates, • Mountains • Seas – Mediterranean, Black, Aegean, Red Social, Cultural, Economic, and Political Geographic Characteristics • Monumental architecture • Trade routes • Political boundaries • City-states

Priority Performance Indicator (PPI)	Sample PPI Connections	Sample Content Connections
Human-Environment Interaction: Place, Regions, and Culture Explain the relationship between culture and environment and how both can change over time. (D2. Geo. 4, 5, 6)	Students will analyze how geographic and cultural characteristics shaped the identities and decision-making of people in early civilizations.	Geographic Features: flooding (predictable/unpredictable), soil (fertile/unfertile), natural barriers (coast/desert), valuable resources (gold/salt) Decisions: Positive • Agriculture: Crop rotation, terrace farming, irrigation • Technology: Metallurgy, wheel, plow, arch, calendar, The Royal Road, Maritime development and trade Negative • Soil erosion from farming and mining • Dam construction affecting natural water cycle • Over-irrigation • Resource depletion – forests, minerals, water over-extraction

Priority Performance Indicator (PPI)	Sample PPI Connections	Sample Content Connections
Human Population: Spatial Patterns and Movements Explain how population shifts affect both culture and environment, and how a changing environment can affect human settlement patterns. (D2. Geo. 7, 8, 9)	Students will be able to identify the ways in which early societies interacted and spread from one region to another. Students will be able to describe how environmental and cultural characteristics affected the distribution and movement of people, goods, and ideas in ancient early civilizations. Students will be able to explain the cultural impact of major population shifts in early civilizations.	Interaction Effects: • Trade • cultural or linguistic exchanges • migration • religious conversion • conquest • Colonization Migrations: Indo-European: Roughly 4000–1000 BCE • Region: Originating from the Pontic-Caspian Steppe (modern-day Ukraine and southern Russia), Indo-European-speaking peoples migrated in multiple waves across Europe and into Asia. • Key Movements: • To Europe: Into the Balkans, Central Europe, and eventually Western Europe (Celts, Italic, Germanic groups) • To South Asia: Around 1500 BCE, the Indo-Aryans moved into the Indian subcontinent, contributing to the Vedic culture • To Anatolia and Iran: Hittites (in Anatolia) and Iranians (Medes, Persians) in the Iranian Plateau

Priority Performance Indicator (PPI)	Sample PPI Connections	Sample Content Connections
Human Population: Spatial Patterns and Movements (continued)	(continued)	Semitic: From around 3000 BCE onward • Region: Originating in the Arabian Peninsula and Near East, Semitic peoples spread throughout the Fertile Crescent, Levant, and Northeast Africa. • Key Movements: Akkadians in Mesopotamia (~2300 BCE) Semitic: From around 3000 BCE onward (continued) • Amorites, Assyrians, and Babylonians in the Near East • Phoenicians along the Levantine coast, later establishing colonies like Carthage (~1200–800 BCE) • Arabs expanding from the Arabian Peninsula, especially in later periods (including Islamic expansions in the 7th century CE) Bantu: Circa 1000 BCE to 1700 CE • Region: Originated in West-Central Africa (modern-day Cameroon/Nigeria area) and gradually spread throughout Sub-Saharan Africa. • Key Movements: • Migrated south and east into the Congo Basin, Great Lakes region, and as far as Southern Africa • Spread agriculture, ironworking, and Bantu languages, which now dominate much of Sub-Saharan Africa.

Priority Performance Indicator (PPI)	Sample PPI Connections	Sample Content Connections
Human Population: Spatial Patterns and Movements (continued)	(continued)	Berber: Ancient to Medieval (starting before 1000 BCE) • Region: Indigenous to North Africa (Maghreb region: modern Morocco, Algeria, Tunisia, Libya) • Key Movements: • Prehistoric spread across the Sahara when it was more habitable (Green Sahara period, ~7000–3000 BCE) • Interactions with Phoenicians, Romans, Vandals, and Arabs • Berbers played a key role in the spread of Islam across North Africa and into Al-Andalus (Spain) during the 7th–8th centuries CE. Nubian Movements: From ~2500 BCE through Classical Antiquity • Region: Upper Nile region, primarily in what is now southern Egypt and northern Sudan. • Key Movements: • Early Nubian cultures like Kerma (~2500–1500 BCE) • Kingdom of Kush (1000 BCE–350 CE), which at one point ruled over Egypt as the 25th Dynasty (ca. 747–656 BCE) • Nubians moved between Nubia and Egypt frequently due to trade, warfare, and political alliances • Later Christian Nubian kingdoms (e.g., Nobatia, Makuria) resisted Islamic expansion for centuries.

Priority Performance Indicator (PPI)	Sample PPI Connections	Sample Content Connections
Human Population: Spatial Patterns and Movements (continued)	(continued)	Persian Empire: Primary expansion 550–330 BCE (Achaemenid Empire) • Region: Originating in Persia (modern Iran) and expanding across Southwest Asia, Central Asia, the Caucasus, the Indus Valley, and into Egypt and parts of Greece. • Key Movements: • Cyrus the Great founded the Achaemenid Empire (~550 BCE), conquering Media, Lydia, Babylon; Under Darius I and Xerxes, expansion reached its peak; Included a diverse range of peoples; the empire used roads and communication systems to link its territories. Impact of geography on settlement patterns: • Nile River • Tigris and Euphrates Rivers • Niger River • Fertile plains • City development – Sumer, Timbuktu, Persepolis, Babylon

Priority Performance Indicator (PPI)	Sample PPI Connections	Sample Content Connections
Human Population: Spatial Patterns and Movements (continued)	(continued)	Impact of geography on settlement patterns: (continued) • Coastal regions • Deserts • Mountains • Arabian Peninsula • Red Sea • Mecca • Medina • Israel • Palestine Environmental Characteristics • Rivers and waterways • Deserts and trade routes • Geographical features • Climate and agricultural practices • Nomadic farming/herding

Priority Performance Indicator (PPI)	Sample PPI Connections	Sample Content Connections
Human Population: Spatial Patterns and Movements (continued)	(continued)	Cultural Characteristics • Religious and cultural centers • Intellectual hubs • Cultural Diffusion • Trade network expansion • Technology transfer • State formation • Urbanization • Migration • Innovation and technological exchange • Trade and economic practices • Language and communication • Political and social structures • Pyramids and Ziggurats • Cultural exchange • Political power dynamics • Economic growth

Priority Performance Indicator (PPI)	Sample PPI Connections	Sample Content Connections
Global Interconnections: Changing Spatial Patterns Describe how spatial patterns can be transformed through natural and man-made disturbances, and how patterns vary across the world and can change over time. (D2. Geo. 10, 11, 12)	Students will be able to explain how human-made and natural catastrophic events affect people living there and in other places (e.g., famine, war, flooding, etc.)	Natural Disturbances: • Saharan Expansion • Holocene Climate Optimum – increase of aridity • Flooding – Tigris and Euphrates • Earthquakes – Anatolia and Levant Man-made transformations: • Agriculture – Long-term irrigation • Empire building – Akkadians, Assyrians, Persians, Egyptians; roads, gridded cities, military garrisons, trade networks • Conflicts and invasions • Spread of religion – pilgrimage routes, mosques

Resources

[Ancient Agrarian Societies: Nubia and Ancient Egypt](#) - OER - History Project: In this reading, students will learn about the Nile River Valley. Best known for pyramids and mummies, communities in this area, such as Egypt and Nubia, were founded long before the first pyramid.

[Ancient Egypt](#) - OER- History Project: Ancient Egypt was the site of some of the world's oldest agrarian societies. Over 5,000 years ago, Egyptian pharaohs first rose to power and built mighty empires and astounding monuments. For 3,000 years, Egyptian pharaohs ruled the lands of the Nile River Valley. The Nile River was the key to Egypt's success. In this article [with guiding questions], you'll learn about how the river shaped Ancient Egypt and the people who lived there from c. 3400 to 30 BCE.

[Ancient Hebrews](#) - C3IDM: This C3 Inquiry leads students through an investigation of ancient Hebrew history and Judaism by using various sources that consider the historical and theological foundations, as well as issues related to geography and place. By investigating the compelling question, students examine the history of the ancient Hebrew people, the principles that form the foundation of Judaic thought, the connection of history and religion to Israel, and the geographic variance in religious practices. By completing this inquiry, students begin to understand issues revolving around the factors that help to form a people's identity, as well as the fluidity of defining a group within any predetermined criteria.

[Building the Pyramids of Ancient Egypt](#) - PBS learning Media: In this interactive lesson supporting literacy skills, students learn how historians think the pyramids were built and why they were built—as doorways to the afterlife for the pharaohs. Students develop their literacy skills as – OER – Big History Project. They explore a social studies focus on ancient Egyptian society and how those at the top organized the rest of the population in order to build these amazing structures. During this process, they read informational text, learn and practice vocabulary words, and explore content through videos and interactive activities.

[Egyptian Flooding](#) - C3 IDM: This inquiry focuses on the impact of the flooding of the Nile River on ancient Egypt, specifically the costs and benefits of the flooding. Through examination and analysis of various photographs, videos, and article excerpts, students will consider how these sources can be used to convey the impact of flooding on multiple groups of people in ancient Egypt.

Egypt's Pyramids: Monuments with a Message - National Endowment for the Humanities: By introducing students to artifacts and archaeology, this lesson considers pyramids as artifacts and examines the scale of these great structures and asks what clues pyramids give us about the ancient Egyptians.

Marco Polo lessons from the National Endowment for the Humanities (grades 6-8 adaptable curriculum):

- **On the Road with Marco Polo: From Venice to Hormuz:** Marco Polo's father and uncle returned to Venice when he was 15 years old. Two years later, when they set off again for China, they decided to take Marco with them. Students will take a “virtual” trip with Marco Polo from Venice to China and back. The first leg of the journey ends at Hormuz.
- **On the Road with Marco Polo: A Boy in 13th Century Venice:** Marco Polo was one of the first Europeans to travel to China. Marco grew up in the 13th century in Venice, an important trading city in Italy. Here, students learn about the Venice of Marco Polo's time.
- **On the Road with Marco Polo: From Hormuz to Venice:** Marco Polo was on the last leg of his journey home from China to Venice. After visiting several seaports in India, he and his party sailed across the Arabian Sea and to the mouth of the Persian Gulf, landing at the port city of Hormuz, where they decided to travel eastward across Asia following a land route.

Trekking to Timbuktu Teacher and Student Versions of Lessons 1-8 - National Endowment for the Humanities:

For many people, Timbuktu is a metaphor for the mysterious, the remote, or the unobtainable. But the Malian city of Timbuktu was, in fact, once a thriving center of commerce and intellectual activity. In the lessons of this unit, students will learn about the geography of Mali and the early trade networks that flourished there. They will study how the spread of Islam influenced the cultures and economies along the Niger River. They will find out about the three kingdoms that evolved in ancient and medieval West Africa.

History

Critical Proficiency (K-12): Students understand and evaluate change and continuity over time, recognize the multiplicity of points of view and make appropriate use of historical evidence in answering questions and developing arguments about the past.

Theme: Building Societies

Priority Performance Indicator (PPI)	Sample PPI Connections	Sample Content Connections
Change, Continuity, and Context Create a chronological sequence to compare and contrast developments within a similar time period, with a focus on analyzing specific individuals or groups who shaped significant changes. (D2. His. 1, 3)	Students will be able to explain the origins and structures of governance in early civilizations. Students will be able to identify the contributions to our understanding of early civilizations from archaeological sites (e.g., Egyptian pyramids).	Emerging Governance • Origins: Centralization of authority – Code of Hammurabi, influence of trade, coordination of agricultural activities, interactions with neighboring cultures, maintenance of order, resource management, deterrence, belief systems, resource allocation. • Structures: Development of legal principles, influence of legal codes, Hammurabi’s Code, Islamic Law in Mali, 10 Commandments, communication infrastructure, patriarchy, city-state, pharaonic monarchy, monarchy, republic, oligarchy, kingdom, tribal councils, empires, caliphs Structures of Early Governance • Kingdom of Mali – Mansu Musa’s Reign; Islamic Golden Age; Code of Ur- Nammu; Code of Hammurabi; Ancient Arabia; Kingdom of Axum; Achaemenid Empire – Cyrus the Great; Mesopotamia; Ancient Egypt – Ma’at; Darius the Great Archaeological Sites • Western Africa/Middle East: Gobekli Tepe, Uruk, Tell Brak • North Africa: Nabta Playa, Giza Pyramids and Saqqara • Sub-Saharan Africa: Jenne-Jeno, Great Zimbabwe Comparisons • Tools, shelter, diet, use of fire, cave paintings, artifacts, clothing, rituals, daily life, gender roles.

Priority Performance Indicator (PPI)	Sample PPI Connections	Sample Content Connections
Perspectives Explain why individuals and groups during the same historical period had similar and /or different perspectives, and how those perspectives shaped the sources they influenced. (D2. His. 4-6)	Students will be able to explain the origins, similarities and differences of early religion by exploration of early texts and artifacts (e.g., Quran).	Historical Origins of Religion • Migrations of the ancient Israelite tribes from Mesopotamia to the land called Canaan; the role of Abraham and Moses in Hebrew history. • History of ancient Israel and early Christianity • Monotheistic religion (e.g., the belief in one God, the Ten Commandments, the emphasis on individual worth and personal responsibility, the belief that rulers and the ruled must adhere to the same moral obligations) • The Hebrew Bible’s accounts of the history of early Israel; Torah • The emergence of Christianity as a distinct religion, with roots in Judaism • The central features of Christianity (e.g., the belief in a messiah who could redeem humans from sin, the concept of salvation, the belief in an Old and a New Testament in the Bible, the life and teachings of Jesus). • Islam’s historical relationship to Judaism and Christianity as monotheistic religions. • The life and teachings of Muhammad (570-c. 632 CE) and the significance of the Qur’an as the primary source of Islamic belief.

Priority Performance Indicator (PPI)	Sample PPI Connections	Sample Content Connections
Causation and Argumentation Explain probable causes and effects of events and developments. (D2, His. 14)	Students will be able to explain reasons for the rise and decline of major empires and civilizations. Students will be able to identify key characteristics, contributions, and achievements of early civilizations.	Rise • Trade and economic prosperity • Cultural achievements • Military power, conquests, and expansions Fall • Internal conflict • External invasions/war/conquests • Internal dissent • Environmental factors Innovations/lasting impacts: • Mathematics/number system • Communication – hieroglyphics/cuneiform • Human anatomy • Government/leadership structure • Culture (e.g., religion/beliefs, accepted practices/traditions) • Specialization of labor • Mastery of food supply • Technology • Economic systems • Education • Communication systems (e.g., spoken language, alphabetic and/or numeric systems, hieroglyphics, illustrations)

Priority Performance Indicator (PPI)	Sample PPI Connections	Sample Content Connections
Causation and Argumentation (continued)	(continued)	Innovations/lasting impacts: (continued) • Military tactics • Maritime power and trade • Architecture • Trade and diplomacy • Legal code • Astronomy • Human Rights (Cyrus Cylinder)

Resources

Cave Art: Discovering Prehistoric Humans through Pictures - National Endowment for the Humanities: By studying paintings from the Cave of Lascaux (France) and the Blombos Cave (South Africa), students will discover that pictures can be a way of communicating beliefs and ideas and can give us clues today about what life was like long ago.

Egyptian Symbols and Figures: Hieroglyphs - National Endowment for the Humanities: In this adaptable 6-8 lesson, students will examine the art and history of ancient Egypt through the oldest writing system in the world. This lesson teaches students how to understand and write Egyptian hieroglyphs.

Into the Field: Archaeology - PBS Learning Media: A collection of archaeology videos and lesson plans for classroom or home use.

Life in Old Babylonia: The Importance of Trade - National Endowment for the Humanities: Trade was critical to Old Babylonia, where many highly prized natural resources were scarce but agricultural goods were in surplus. Trade became integral to the economy and the culture. In this lesson, students explore the trade industry in Old Babylonia and its far-flung influence.

Refugee - C3 IDM: This inquiry leads students through an investigation of how we respond to the needs of refugee communities. With the example of King Najashi (in the 7th century Kingdom of Aksum, modern Eritrea), students an

historical instance of a national leader extending compassion to a refugee community. Students examine contemporary examples of national leaders who do and do not demonstrate care to refugee or immigrant communities. To close the inquiry, students consider how local activist take actions related to refugee populations with the example late hip-hop artist and activist Nipsey Hussle whose father was an Eritrean refugee. By connecting a historical example to a modern context, students use world history to construct an argument and take informed action around the compelling question: *When should refugees be allowed refuge?* (Grades 6-8)

The Cuneiform Writing System in Ancient Mesopotamia: Emergence and Evolution - National Endowment for the Humanities: The earliest writing systems evolved independently and at roughly the same time in Egypt and Mesopotamia, but current scholarship suggests that Mesopotamia's writing appeared first. That writing system, invented by the Sumerians, emerged in Mesopotamia around 3500 BCE. This lesson plan is designed to help students appreciate the parallel development and increasing complexity of writing and civilization in Mesopotamia.

The Phoenicians and the Beginnings of the Alphabet - National Endowment for the Humanities: This is an adaptable K-5 lesson where students learn about the Phoenicians as a trading people who invented the first form of our alphabet.